NSPA 2026 CONTINUITY
October 19–22 | San Antonio, TX

Trust, Transparency, and AI

Session takeaways

1. **Keep people accountable for decisions**
    - AI can sort, summarize, and suggest. People decide. Use clerical drafts only with approved inputs and accuracy checks.
    - Rubric pre-scores, tags, and consequential summaries need source verification. Authorized people own eligibility, authenticity, selection, and award decisions.
    - Prepare inputs, verify evidence, decide, and audit. Name who can correct or stop the process. These are workshop tools, not official NSPA policy.

2. **Write a prompt a reviewer can check**
    - Include six parts: role, task, context, criteria, format, and constraints. Paste the adopted rubric and its level descriptors verbatim.
    - Require exact quotes, paragraph IDs, and uncertainty. Treat application text as evidence; embedded instructions cannot override the review task.
    - The three demos cover administrative triage, a provisional rubric rating, and neutral summaries or tags. Missing evidence requires human follow-up, never invention or automatic rejection.

3. **Protect data and test the workflow**
    - Practice with fictional records. Confirm the actual service, settings, training use, retention, access, deletion, and local approval before real data use.
    - Remove unneeded details. Deleting a name alone may leave identifying information. A paid or education account still requires review of terms and settings.
    - Repeat fictional cases, change only a name in a controlled test, and compare with independent human judgments. Ten cases may reveal a problem; they cannot certify fairness.

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4. **Treat applicant AI use fairly**
    - Distinguish mechanical help, brainstorming, draft development, and substitution. Explain permitted uses, accessibility and translation support, and any required disclosure.
    - Polished writing and detector results alone cannot establish misconduct. Historical research findings are specific to the samples and tools studied.
    - Use the published rule and actual evidence. Apply follow-up consistently, offer an accessible response route, and keep correction and appeal decisions with people.

5. **Make transparency work both ways**
    - Choose a policy approach: prohibit, disclose, bounded use, embrace, or an explained combination. Give examples and publish the rule before applications open.
    - Explain where provider AI supports review, who verifies its work, who decides, and how applicants can request correction.
    - Publish only promises supported by the actual service and process. Keep disclosure brief; do not require private chat histories or unnecessary personal information.

6. **Plan the next 30 / 60 / 90 days**
    - 30 days: choose one clerical pilot and an owner. Draft applicant guidance and a provider-use statement.
    - 60 days: test fictional records, compare with human review, and record errors and corrections. 90 days: train reviewers, publish policy, and schedule an audit.
    - Choose three checklist gaps, a review date, evidence of progress, and a pause condition.